

***Civil Rights History Project
Interview completed by the Southern Oral History Program
under contract to the
Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of African American History & Culture
and the Library of Congress, 2013***

Interviewee: Samuel J. Young, Jr.
Interview Date: March 9, 2013
Location: Campus of Albany State University, Albany, Georgia
Interviewer: Willie Griffin
Videographer: John Bishop
Length: 00:42:08

[Throughout interview, sounds of conversation are occasionally heard in the background]

John Bishop: Ready to roll.

Willie Griffin: Okay. Today is Saturday, March 9th, 2013. My name is Willie Griffin, and I am a research associate with the Southern Oral History Program at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. I am with videographer John Bishop in Albany, Georgia, on the campus of Albany State University to conduct an interview for the Civil Rights History Project, which is a joint undertaking of the Smithsonian National Museum of African American History and Culture and the Library of Congress. We are here today with Mr. Sam Young, Jr. Thank you so much for being here, Mr. Young, and agreeing to share your story with the Civil Rights History Project.

Sam Young, Jr.: Thank you.

WG: Alright. So, I just want to begin, first off, by having you state your full name and tell when and where you were born.

SY: Okay. My name is Samuel J. Young, Jr., and I was born in Worth County, Sylvester, Georgia, [mic movement sounds] March 13th, 1950.

WG: Okay. March 13th, 1950. Okay. So, what was it like growing up? In 1950, you were right on the cusp of the *Brown vs. Board of Education*. What else is going on? The Korean War is—

SY: Okay. In the 1950s, you know, growing up, I was very aware of certain issues like, you know, the Board of Education thing, you know. And my father, he was very political.

WG: Okay.

SY: And he always kept us abreast on different issues. But I did not understand what that was all about, you know, during when he was telling me about it.

WG: What was your father's name?

SY: About the Board of Education, you know.

WG: Your father's name was Sam Young, Sr.?

SY: Right, senior. Right, he was Samuel J. Young, Sr., and he was very influential in the political scene and he always kept us abreast about, you know, different political issues that were going on around us.

WG: Okay.

SY: And he made us watch the news, you know, every day. And when it come time—when I really understood was, you know, after I became older and had some of the issues face me head-on. And then I understood a lot of things, you know, that he would be speaking of.

WG: Okay. So, like, for example, in Worth County, did you experience, I mean, any of this—the signs of racism growing up in Worth County?

SY: Oh, yes, especially during school integration.

WG: Okay.

SY: You know, because when I went to—at that time, it was the freedom of choice, you know, if you wanted to go.

WG: Right.

SY: You know, that was one of the, I guess, one of the things that they did to keep people from actually—

WG: Fully integrating.

SY: Right.

WG: Right. So, you had the opportunity to go to a white school if you did, but you could remain in an all-black school if you wanted to?

SY: Right.

WG: Okay.

SY: And lots of my friends, you know, they did exactly that. But I chose to go to the—with the freedom of choice thing, chose to go to the other schools, the white schools.

WG: Okay.

SY: And when I started school, we—our schools were our churches in Worth County.

WG: Right.

SY: And we would walk every day back and forth, you know, to school, and the school buses would come by. And, as I remember, the children, you know, would hang their heads out of the window, you know, calling us racial names and all that.

WG: Right.

SY: But [laughs] we—the bus would always meet at this path. I guess, the timing, when we got out of school, we would always be exactly about the same place. And, you know, little kids, you know, when somebody's messing with you, you know—we threw rocks at the bus! I mean, that's what we did. [Laughter]

And the bus driver would put the lights on, you know, the brake lights. We'd see the brake lights come on.

WG: Right.

SY: And back in those days, they were doing what they call turpentine, you know, where they get the box—scrape the tree and get the, what they called gum, and they would make a lot of our products out of that.

WG: Right.

SY: And the paths in the woods were always clear. And we'd just strike out through the woods, [05:00] and they never would be able to catch us! [Laughter]

WG: [Laughing] They never would catch you.

SY: And I, when I went to school—when they *did* build schools in Worth County—my father said that I could not read. And I had a sister coming into the first grade at that same time. I was supposed to have been in the second grade. And we went through school together, you know, and everybody thought we were twins, but we were not.

WG: Right.

SY: My father kept me back, because he said I could not read, and I'm very glad that he did that, because I probably couldn't. Looking at some of my grandchildren sometimes, and even my own kids, you know, I knew that they were not qualified, you know, to read. And I'm glad he

cared about that. And I had the kind of teachers that you didn't escape. There was no net. You had to get your lesson, you know.

WG: Right.

SY: And you had to—there was no cheating.

WG: And you weren't just going to disappear in the back of the classroom.

SY: Oh, no! That was not going to happen.

WG: Right.

SY: And once, I remember—I always tell my grandkids this story, you know, about trying to cheat—I was caught sitting on a spelling book. And the teacher came back to me, and she says, “Young, are you cheating?” And I said, “No.” She said, “Well, stand up!” And when I stood up, you know, the spelling book was right there.

And she spanked me. And then, I remember, you know, getting, I guess, upset and saying, “I’m going to tell my father. I’m going to tell my mother.” Now, in *those* days, you know what she said? “Come on, let’s go! I’ll *take* you to them!” [Laughter] Because—

WG: [Laughing] We’re going to see who’s right.

SY: Hey! I really didn’t want that to happen! [Laughter]

WG: So, you’re posturing? [Laughs]

SY: But that’s some of the things that happened. And when the schools integrated, you know, I’m under the impression that, you know, okay, that the white people are way smarter. I’m going into—with this expectation, you know. And I had a—oh, it was a very awakening experience.

And then, when you let—one other thing that my parents taught me: You never follow the crowd. You were born an individual and you will die an individual.

WG: Right.

SY: And that's one—I do that even today. Even though some issues might be, you know—if I decide to go along, it's that we—it's just a universal thing that everything is, you know, good.

WG: Right.

SY: And I'll go along. But if I've got some issues with it, I will not do it.

WG: You won't do it.

SY: You know, just because of the group, you know.

WG: Right.

SY: And we had several incidents of racist, racial things to happen. They came out to our church, some kids, you know, just basically kids doing things, you know. And they painted the front of our church, the same church that I grew up at and went to school a lot at.

WG: What was the name of the church?

SY: Blue Spring Baptist Church in Warwick, Georgia.

WG: Okay.

[Recording stops and then resumes]

WG: Okay, go ahead, continue.

SY: And—

WG: So, they painted some things on the church?

SY: Painted the church black and said, written, that “This is the house of the devil's den,” or something like that. But we found out that it was one of the local vendors' son that did it, and he made him go back out and repaint the whole thing because of what he had did, you know.

And we had some other incidents, you know. As a matter of fact, my cousin—two of my cousins were taken into custody at Worth County High, because she and a white guy got into it and she beat him. [Laughter] They came and arrested her right off the school bus. They took them, brought them over—they were in Worth County. They brought them over to Albany at the Youth Detention Center here, and the sheriff would not tell my aunt [10:00] where those kids were.

WG: Was this Pritchett? Was this still Pritchett in Albany?

SY: No, no, this was in—

WG: Oh, the sheriff of Worth wouldn't tell?

SY: He was—I think it was. At that time, I believe it was a Pritchett, but it was not the one here in Albany.

WG: Okay.

SY: I'm not sure whether they were related or not.

WG: Right.

SY: But at the time, Attorney C. B. King was a very prominent black lawyer here. And they—it was only—the children were out of place for three days before the sheriff would tell. He would not—my aunt went down to the jail—they would not tell her where her children were.

WG: Your cousin can't be any more than fourteen, maybe thirteen?

SY: Maybe, somewhere in that neighborhood. And they took her, took those two kids, and C. B. threatened to have the sheriff arrested. And at that point, he told where the children were, and they were over here in Albany. But beforehand, you know, they would not release the location of where those children were.

WG: Right.

SY: You know, and it was kind of scary.

WG: Because that's illegal.

SY: Because we were young. And, you know, when somebody take some part of your family, and nobody's telling you where they are, and understanding some of the issues that were with black people going on all over the country, especially in the South, we were assuming, as children, that they might be, you know, deceased or something.

WG: Right. And this was the police, not just some vigilante group—

SY: Yeah! So, that was that. And I have seen—not seen, but I have been in the presence of a lot of things. I even had some people that were shot, because they were trying to break up a fight, and there was a guy that came out and just, you know, shot them, you know, just because, I guess, you know, he was the white guy.

WG: And you were school-aged at this time?

SY: I was school-aged during that time, right. All these things are—happened. Lots of things happened. Then, once, I remember, my father was our Sunday School teacher also. And I remember one of the deacons, one of my—you know, kids, we all grew up with our church family.

WG: Right.

SY: And he came to work—not to work, but he *had been* to work, and he came. He got shot. The guy that he was working for, the son of his employer wanted him to call him—this man was probably three times his senior, because he was a teenager—but he wanted him to call him, the young guy wanted him to call him “Mister.” So, he said, “No. I’m not going to call you ‘Mister.’”

WG: [Laughs] That's ridiculous.

SY: And so, the father—he went to the father and told the father about it. And the father, without asking my friend's and those father anything about it, he just came out with his shotgun.

WG: Wow.

SY: And the only reason—I'll always remember—I couldn't understand how another human being could do such things to one another, you know.

WG: Right.

SY: But he got shot. And the only reason that he didn't get blinded or killed was he threw his hands up, you know, as a shield. And I remember in Sunday School, he was telling about the story and, you know, the buckshot. You know, he had all the pellets and stuff where they penetrated the skin and in his face.

WG: So, this guy was aiming—

SY: And he would have been blinded.

WG: He was aiming for his head!

SY: Yeah! And he just—it was some terrible times. It was some terrible times, and things may have changed, and they may not have changed.

WG: Do you remember this guy's name at all, the one who got shot?

SY: His name was Albert Gill.

WG: Albert Gill?

SY: Oh, the one that got shot?

WG: Yeah.

SY: Oh, no, his name was C. T. Rockwell.

WG: C. T. Rockwell, and Albert Gill was who?

SY: The shooter.

WG: Okay.

SY: Right.

WG: Good, yeah. Albert Gill. [15:00]

SY: But sometimes, you know, I think back. I have some embedded hatred for, you know, some times. *But*, as I grow older, I look at things. And, even though there were a lot of things, you know, directed—you know, the racial things directed toward my father, because they were black landowners.

WG: Right.

SY: And loans were foreclosed, you know—everything, you know. And I remember there was a local white grocer. He also had a hardware store. And he extended my father a line of credit, you know, to farm with, and that's how we made it through those times. And we—he—my father rented our property from him for years. I never understood it, but—after he quit farming, you know.

But, see, farming for young black men, you know, and for the farm, you know, the land, and all that to be passed on to the black people, there was nothing. You know, there was no—and I look now. Even the farmers around us and their kids, generations of them, you know, the land and the farming business is passed on and on and on to them. But there was no such thing for black people. And just recently, I guess, there are a lot of opportunities. You know, after the, uh—the—oh, man—the ASCS office.

WG: ASCS?

SY: They got sued. They changed it to Farm Services now. And there are a lot of things out there that are good for young black farmers. But our—I think, you know, we went through an era where, you know, a farm was work.

WG: Right.

SY: We don't want to put out that kind of [laughs]—

WG: And you learned it from your father?

SY: Right. I grew up on the farm.

WG: Okay. What were some of the things you planted?

SY: Oh, we planted cotton, corn, peanuts, vegetables, squash, butterbeans, peas, okra.

WG: Okay.

SY: And then, we were the ones, our children—you know, I'm from a large family.

WG: Uh-huh. How many brothers and sisters?

SY: I've got ten sisters—I had ten sisters, and there were seven brothers.

WG: Whoa!

SY: And I see—[laughs] when I think about it, you know, we had the large family because *we* were going to be the ones to gather the crops and everything, which wasn't bad, because I learned a lot of experiences about work, you know. And I was the oldest son, and I had two sisters that were all older than I am.

And we all graduated from schools in Worth County, you know, when the odds were basically against you receiving a pretty good education or just, you know, receiving a diploma. And I graduated—I was the only—in 1968 is when I graduated, and I think, as I remember, I might have been the only black male, you know, in that group.

WG: In that class, wow.

SY: You know, it's probably about four or five black ladies.

WG: What was the name of the high school you graduated from?

SY: Worth County High in Sylvester, Georgia.

WG: Okay, Worth County High. So, and you graduated in 1968, and—

SY: '68.

WG: '68, and that was a really critical time in '68, supposedly.

SY: Hey! [Laughs] *Very!*

WG: Right.

SY: Very critical.

WG: The Civil Rights Movement is supposedly ending, and the Black Power Movement emerges.

SY: But that was—

WG: I'm sorry. Let's pause for just a second.

JB: Yeah, the hard disk is full. We don't want to miss this.

WG: Okay.

[Recording stops and then resumes]

WG: Do you remember her sister's name?

JB: We're going.

SY: Excuse me?

WG: Her sister's name?

SY: Oh, Yvonne.

WG: Yvonne, okay.

JB: Could you just—I have the cameras running now—could you just say the names of the two girls on the bus?

SY: Oh, Dorothy and Yvonne Young.

JB: Could you say it just as a sentence? So, say, “Those two that were taken off the bus, their names were—”

SY: Dorothy Young and Yvonne Young. I can’t quite—[20:00]

Unidentified Female: What they want you to do is to give them a complete sentence that says, “The two girls who were taken off the bus were Dorothy and Yvonne.”

SY: Okay. The two girls—

WG: Yeah, that’s right.

SY: Go?

WG: Yeah.

SY: Okay. The two girls that were taken off the bus were my first cousins, Dorothy Young and Yvonne Young.

WG: Okay, that’s good.

JB: Thanks.

WG: Alright. So, we’ll go back to 1968, and you’re graduating. And, again, this is a really critical time in African American history.

SY: Yeah, 1968 I graduated. And after high school, my first public job that I had was—there was a Firestone or a tire plant here, and I—that was my first job, you know. And I ran into some pretty tough supervisors there, you know.

WG: Okay.

SY: So, I changed—I didn’t—they let me go, along with some other people. And then, I found out about the—I had two older sisters that were working with the Southwest Georgia Project for community education.

WG: Okay. Could you—I'm sorry. Before you move on, could you just talk about those supervisors at Firestone when you say "tough"?

SY: Oh, they were—they were mean. They were pretty mean. And I'm working. You know, I'm working. I'm breaking a terrible sweat, you know.

WG: Right.

SY: And right after high school, you know, I'm figuring I'm, you know—that's when I realized that I needed some more education. Because when I got out and I went on the job site, they were building the [laughs] you know, they're forming the building that was going to have some heavy machines sitting there, you know, the tire machines that were going to build the tires.

WG: Okay.

SY: And so, they were—the forms were way down, you know, like in the ground. You had to climb down there on a ladder, you know, and bust the forms up around the concrete.

WG: Okay.

SY: So, I was thinking, "Well, you know, I'm educated. I got out of high school, you know, but I'm going to be doing some—." They gave me a pick and a shovel! [Laughter] And I had to go down in there. And it was terrible, but I was working. But they—I guess I wasn't meeting their criteria or something.

WG: Okay.

SY: And so, I went. And then, I worked with the Southwest Georgia Project from like 19—up until '83. I went to school, because we had said we were going to start a newspaper, you know, and I went to Albany Technical College to learn graphic art, you know, run the machines

and everything. But farming is what I love. You know, I grew up with it. It's hard work, but it pays off when you do it right. And so, I worked mostly with the farm part.

WG: Okay. Could you tell us what the Southwest Georgia Project was, I mean, when you were introduced to it?

SY: It was a community education group, you know, and it covered the Southwest Georgia area. We had people, you know, in all of the counties that would come here. And it also had scholarship programs. It sent a lot of people to, you know, different colleges, and got scholarships for them, things like that.

WG: Okay. Was this how you got into Albany Technical College? Did you get a scholarship through the Southwest Georgia Project?

SY: Oh, yes, basically.

WG: Okay. So, who were some of the first people in the project that, you know, sort of showed you the ropes? Or who did you work under, or who did you work with?

SY: I worked basically on the Charles Sherrod end. There were other people. Some of them are—have deceased since then. One of them was Randolph Battle. He was a good mentor of mine. I was young. You know, these guys like took me under their wings and taught me a whole lot of things. And another one was Robert Mants.

WG: Robert Mants.

SY: And he was another one that—you know, they took me in and taught me a lot of things about politics and, you know, how to handle things and all that. You know, I took it in, because I was all ears, you know. [Laughter] I took it in.

And Mants passed maybe a couple of years ago—[25:00] well, not even quite a couple of year. And we did—we talked. And he had a heart attack. But, you know, you're talking about

things that happened, and it was amazing that, you know, where we have basically come to reach a conclusion on a lot of things. We were seeing basically down the road together on that. And I'm not sure whether you all are familiar with attorney Mary Young.

WG: Attorney Mary Young, that name sounds familiar. Could you talk a little bit about her?

SY: She was another champion for the Civil Rights Movement in this area.

WG: Okay.

SY: She defended a lot of people, you know, black and white. And she also—she handled a lot of divorce cases and different things like that.

WG: Okay.

SY: And she also—she worked as a—she came in under Attorney C. B. King when she first came to Albany.

WG: Okay.

SY: Yeah.

WG: Yeah, I think I met her last time in 2009.

SY: Right.

WG: Okay.

SY: She was a real person.

WG: Okay. So, let's talk about school, then, you know, for the graphic arts.

SY: Oh, graphic art, you know, it's a printing—you learn to run the printing presses. You learn to do the graphics, like on this book, you know, pictures and stuff like that. And then, you know, you do the plates, the negatives, and you take it to the machine and you run them. And,

you know, typeset, you know, you set the columns, all that. You know, you learn some of that, but I never could do that because my hands were so—

WG: Were so big. [Laughs]

SY: Large. [Laughs] I couldn't do that, so we always got somebody, you know, to do that. Yeah.

WG: Okay. So, talk about when you—the Southwest Georgia Project—when you got involved in farming in the project.

SY: I got involved in it, the Southwest Georgia Project—New Communities, Incorporated, which was the land deal, was a project of the Southwest Georgia Project, you know, and that's how I got involved in it. Sherrod went to New York and found out that the land was for sale here in Southwest Georgia.

WG: In Southwest Georgia?

SY: But nobody—you know, it wasn't posted, but he found out about it up in New York.

WG: Okay.

SY: And he pursued the idea to the point where, you know, funds was raised, and then, the acquisition of the land, you know, was made.

WG: So, the idea was to purchase this huge tract—?

SY: To purchase land and become, you know, self-sufficient.

WG: For black communities, just create a new community?

SY: Right, exactly.

WG: Okay. And your role in this, when you finally—when did you finally secure the land?

SY: It had to be in '68.

WG: Okay.

SY: 1968.

WG: Okay. So, you were just graduating out of high school?

SY: I was right out of high school.

WG: Okay.

SY: But I was still also a member of the Southwest Georgia Project, an active member.

WG: Right.

SY: And that was good. We did a lot of things, and also we would have a lot of students come down from different states, you know, a lot of youth. A lot of youth was involved into it. And it was a great thing. It would have been even greater, but in the '70s, the FHA—I think that's what it is—the FHA or the ASCS, you know, they foreclosed on a lot of black farmers in the area.

WG: Okay.

SY: You know, and that's basically what happened.

WG: So, how long—I mean, let's back up. You said these children were coming to the farm, and they were learning.

SY: People from the—like we'd come to a town, get a bunch of children to go out, you know, and learn about farming, you know, how to produce your own food, and pick it, take it to the market, or prepare it for the use in your freezer and stuff like that.

WG: So, you're finally getting to do what you want to do now, right?

SY: Right!

WG: You're showing your skills!

SY: Right. That's basically the idea. And then, we had about—the money crop was the peanut crop. You know, we had—on that farm, there was an allotment of over 300 and some acres [30:00] of peanut. And we had corn. We never did plant cotton. I don't understand—well, we never did. [Laughs]

WG: [Laughing] I can probably understand why!

SY: Nobody wanted to plant no cotton. [Laughs] It never happened!

WG: Right.

SY: But we had corn, vegetables, okra, lots of different things, watermelons, and stuff like that. And we would harvest them and take them to market. But during the time of—well, you know, I'm—are you familiar with the suit that—

WG: No. Take us through that.

SY: So, when they did the class action suit, you know, the government against the—I guess it was ASCS—I know that the federal government finally admitted that there was discrimination against black farmers, okay, and we came under a class action suit. But it was years and years and years before anything actually—we got any monetary value from that, you know.

WG: Okay. But by then, it was too late. You had really lost the farm.

SY: Right. We had to buy—I think—maybe Sherrod and Charlie know who bought—they bought a new plot of land here in Dougherty County and they've got a lot of things going on with that now.

WG: Okay.

SY: But—

JB: It wasn't like two years or three years?

SY: Excuse me?

JB: It wasn't like two years or three years, the suit?

WG: The suit—how long did it take to materialize?

SY: Matter of fact, it was denied. It had to be sometime in the late '80s and maybe mid '90s.

WG: Okay.

SY: But the final thing came through in 2009, 2008-09.

WG: So, it was some time between—

SY: Exactly. It was a long, long time. Everybody basically had given up on receiving anything. And I think they had disqualified us as a farm because of all the other activities that we were doing for the community and all the other ongoing projects we had going. But eventually, you know, it came under a new ruling. I can't—well, maybe Sherrod or Charlie could tell you a lot more about it.

WG: Okay.

SY: I've forgotten lots of the stuff.

WG: Right. That's understandable. Could you—I'm trying to get a good vision of what this farm looked like and what you lost. You mentioned that you had three hundred acres of peanuts. Were there homes? What else?

SY: Okay. It was dwellings out there. Matter of fact, I lived there from—I got married in '74 and I moved my wife and my children. We moved onto the homesite.

WG: Right.

SY: And there were several other people, you know, also moved out. Some of them were Southwest Georgia Project members, and some people from the local community, you know. And we were the ones to, you know, operate the farm and do all that.

WG: Okay. So, were there homes already on the farm when you bought it?

SY: Right. There were existing homes.

WG: Okay. So, you didn't do any extra building?

SY: No.

WG: Okay.

SY: We didn't exist that long, you know. But all that was in the planning of it, but we never could get any funds, enough to start that going.

WG: Okay.

SY: We were always denied, in other words. These were, you know, the '60s, you know, and any time that black folk got—had control of something that was going to seem like better their lives, it just was not taken kindly by the locals and I guess some other people higher up, you know. So, that's what happened.

WG: So, since the project ended, what have you been doing?

SY: What have *I* been doing?

WG: Yeah, what have you been doing?

SY: Okay, I've been kind of just, you know, maintaining. I need to get back [35:00] involved, you know, because there are just too many things that need to be done. In other words, well, I kind of got disinterested, you know, somewhat, you know. But there's a lot of things that I know that needs to happen, and I know I've got a lot of potential input that I can put into some things, you know, because I look at the situation with our black youth, you know. There were

things that we could be doing to make a difference, you know, here in Southwest Georgia, and probably over the nation, you know, because we have students coming from New York, Chicago, you know.

WG: Right.

SY: So.

WG: So, you think you got—a lot of your disappointment stemmed from, first of all, losing the farm.

SY: Right. Exactly.

WG: And after decades of finally being righted, I mean, when they finally made the decision that they had.

SY: Right. And I may, I probably will eventually—I saw one of the—Mrs. Sherrod. That's how I got directed to here. She was leaving out, and I guess it's just coincidence. The lady was coming out of the parking lot, and I was asking her where was everything. And that was her. And I hadn't seen her in over two years. That's to show you [laughs], you know, how things go.

WG: That's right.

SY: So, that was kind of like an inspiration to me, you know, to get back involved with things.

WG: So, you think that's your next step?

SY: Right.

WG: You're going to get back in?

SY: Um-hmm.

WG: Okay. So, I guess the legacy of the Southwest Georgia Project—I mean, it's still going. I'm not saying that it's ended.

SY: Right. It's still there. It never, you know, it never deceased. It never died out. It was always there, you know. It was not inactive to the point—it always was something going on, you know, with it, you know. But I wasn't involved. You know, I kind of went my own separate way on it.

WG: Okay. Is there anything else you think you might want to share that we should know about your experiences in the Southwest Georgia Project, or any words of wisdom that you'd like to—?

SY: Ahh, words of wisdom. I would say sometimes, you know, you have to be—you have to stand up sometimes, you know, because if you don't, you know—some decisions can take you to the left or too far to the right, but you have to, you know—in other words, address the issues, address it then.

WG: Head-on.

SY: Don't wait until later.

WG: Okay.

SY: Do it then. And then, if it still goes that way, *at least* you'll have made your—you know, had your presentation about it, your discontent or whatever about the situation, you know.

WG: Okay. Alright, Mr. Young.

SY: And how long have we talked? [Laughs]

JB: About three hours? [Laughter]

WG: So, Mr. Young—

SY: There's a lot more, but—

WG: I'm sure, I mean, if you want to—

JB: We have time.

WG: Yeah, we have time. I mean—

SY: I thought y'all were fixing to let me go.

WG: [Laughing] We were going to let you go, but then you said there's a lot more!

JB: Yeah, lock the door.

SY: But, you know, I guess I'm very—on becoming involved with the Southwest Georgia Project, you know, I was able to go see a lot of things, you know, that I know that other kids my age had not seen. I was able to go to New York City, or the Carolinas, lots of places, you know. And I learned also a lot of things there.

WG: Right. And that was a part of the project? They would take you around to places to strategically learn—

SY: They would—there were different organizations that would send, you know, for people to come up and do some things, you know, teach different programs and stuff, different seminars. And I got a chance to get in on a lot of that.

WG: Okay.

SY: Matter of fact, one thing in New York, [40:00] there was a thing called [40:02], you know, where you—what they do is they teach you about solving problems in groups and stuff. They take you and—just like I'm sitting here talking now—and they have you on camera. And then, they give you a whole lot of scenarios, and then, you come up with the best one, you know, to get the—what they were doing was they were developing communications [40:34] and how to do different things, how to solve different problems. And I went through that, and that was the first time I saw myself on camera. [Laughter] So, that was interesting! That was real interesting. I learned a lot.

And then, you're supposed to bring it back, bring that, what you learned, back to your group, you know, and try to implement some of the things, you know, problem solving and things that are facing you, you know, apply that what you learned from those, from their teachings.

WG: Sure.

SY: And—it's a lot. It's coming back, but—[laughs] y'all going to do me again?

[Laughter]

WG: No, but we do want to thank you for coming in and sharing your stories.

SY: Well, I've very—

WG: And if there is an opportunity that you find that you want to share some more, we would definitely be willing.

SY: Okay. But I'm very happy to tell my little microcosm of the story, you know, and hope it means something to someone and hope some of it can be passed on, you know. So, I'm very happy to have been a part of this, and I really thank you for this booklet here, because this is the kind of stuff that I like.

WG: Okay.

SY: So, now, this is *mine*. I'm putting it away. [Laughter]

WG: That's right. Alright. Thank you again, Mr. Young.

SY: Okay. Thank you all.

[Recording ends at 42:08]

END OF INTERVIEW

Transcribed by Sally C. Council